Community-Based Disaster Management

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The Key Elements of Community-Based Disaster Management

In a book published by the Center for Disaster Preparedness (CDP), the "Community-Based Disaster Management in the Philippines: Making a Difference in People's Lives", the following are the key elements of a successful community-based disaster management (CBDM):

1. **People's participation is providing or allowing people more power to be able to participate and contribute to the initiatives in looking for possible answers to many problems and issues including disaster.**
   People or community participation aims at exploring solutions to the issues and concerns in an appropriate way by giving them responsibilities to contribute to the sustainable implementation of disaster activities. Community participation starts from planning to implementation, monitoring, and evaluation. Levels of participation of the community in disaster management activities can be described as a ladder metaphor borrowed from Arnstein (1969) and Hart (1999).

   The description understands that participation often begins from a manipulative stage. An example of this is when the government and NGOs are using community voices for their own interests and without the community's knowledge. In the context of child participation, the lowest level of the metaphor or the bottom step of the ladder describes how the voices of children are used for the interest of adults without their knowledge. The symbol of men and women are additional descriptions illustrating that without gender equality, the ladder of participation will only belong to one particular gender (in this case adult male). In many cases, participation is manipulative and only involves men. Hart (1999) stressed that the situation requires a change of paradigm among disaster risk management project holders (government, NGO, and private sector through CSR programs). At the bottom steps of the ladder of participation are manipulation and top-down.

   According to Arnstein (1969), those two steps are described as levels of "nonparticipation" that overlook the dignity of the community. People's participation is essential in all phases (prevention, mitigation, preparedness, emergency response, recovery, and rehabilitation) and process (disaster risk assessment) of disaster management (Tegum and Janna, 2011).

2. **In community-based disaster management (CBDM), the priority sectors include the vulnerable sectors in the urban areas such as the urban poor and informal settlers and in the rural areas, which consist of the subsistence farmers, fisherfolk, and indigenous people.**
   Also included are the elderly, the differently-abled, children, and women.

3. **In CBDM, the measures applied in risk reduction are community-specific and defined based on the community's disaster risk analysis.**
   The analysis takes into consideration hazards, vulnerabilities, and capacities and the different perceptions on disaster risk.

4. **In CBDM, existing coping mechanisms and capacities are acknowledged.**
   It builds on common social and organizational values and mechanisms such as cooperation, community/people's organization, local knowledge, and resources.

5. **In CBDM, the goal is to reduce vulnerabilities and build resilient communities.**
   Towards this end, it is necessary to strengthen the organizational capacity of the most vulnerable communities through community-based disaster preparedness.

6. **In CBDM, disaster risk reduction also includes addressing the roots of people's vulnerabilities and contributes to transforming and eliminating structures that breed inequity and underdevelopment.**

7. **In CBDM, institutions such as the government and nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) have a role to play.**
   The NGOs have supporting, facilitating, and catalytic roles in disaster risk reduction. Nevertheless, their presence in communities is only temporary. The government's role, on the other hand, is integral in the institutionalization of the CBDM process.

Traditional Approach in Disaster Management

The traditional approaches in disaster management are characterized by the top-down approach and are also non-participative and material need-oriented. The *Pratiyogita Darpan* in its January 2008 publication issue presents some of the views and characteristics of this approach which are listed below:

1. Disasters are unforeseen events that cannot be prevented.
2. The stress is on offering emergency response and recovery.
3. People affected by disasters are helpless victims and passive recipients of external aid.
4. Adults act on behalf of children in responding to children's needs.
5. Disaster management is the sole responsibility of the disaster response agency and specialists such as scientists, economists, social workers, the government, and NGOs.
6. The focus is on physical and material aid and technical solutions.
7. Focus is given to individual households.
8. Donors/outsiders decide on what the families and communities need.
9. Disaster management aims to reduce immediate suffering and meet emergency needs.
10. The goal is to bring things back to normal.

In the traditional approach, the people affected are seldom asked or never asked about their needs. They are not invited to participate or join post-disaster planning and activities geared toward capacity building. The community observes that the government applies traditional processes in disaster response such as the following:

1. The general response is reactive and emergency focused.
2. The actions are, most often than not, relief-centered and limited only to relief distribution and preparation.
3. Rehabilitation works are rarely done.
4. Most of its strategies and approaches are not participatory; and
5. The strategies do not respond to the root causes of people's vulnerability.

Community-Based Disaster Risk Reduction Management Approach

The Community-Based Disaster Risk Reduction Management (CBDRRM), on the other hand, is a process in which at-risk communities are actively engaged in the identification, analysis, treatment, monitoring, and evaluation of disaster risks to reduce their vulnerabilities and enhance their capacities (ADPC 2003). This means that people are at the heart of decision-making and implementation of disaster risk management activities. The CBDRRM indicates that the participation of the most vulnerable social groups is significant, whereas the contribution of the least vulnerable groups is essential for the effective implementation of this approach (Abarquez and Murshed, 2004).

In the past, the prevailing disaster response system in the Philippines was focused on relief operations and emergency response only. Disaster preparedness activities like evacuation drills and simulation exercises, training and education, and other preparedness activities to equip people with knowledge, skills, and attitude were not given much attention.

The Philippine culture of *bayanihan* uplifts the psychological and emotional resiliency of the Filipino people, especially the poor and marginalized. It affirms the value Of involving our local communities in

disaster risk reduction and management. The local communities strive to cope and respond to the impacts of disasters and somehow establish their local coping mechanisms and systems to reduce some of their vulnerabilities.

The CBDRRM process includes:

a. initiating the process and establishing rapport;
b. community risk assessment (hazard, vulnerability, and capacity);
c. participatory community disaster risk reduction and management plan;
d. formation and strengthening of community organization;
e. community-managed implementation of the disaster risk reduction plan;
f. participatory monitoring and evaluation; and
g. progression towards safer, adaptive, and resilient communities (Kafle and Murshed, 2006).

Characteristics and Elements of CBDRRM

The CBDRRM, as indicated by the Citizen's Disaster Response Center, has the following characteristics and elements (Victoria, n.d.):

1. Disasters can be prevented. We can prepare to avoid and reduce damage and losses.
2. The stress is on prevention, mitigation, and preparedness.
3. Pebble' affected by disasters are active actors in rebuilding their life and livelihood.
4. People's existing capacities are used and strengthened.
5. Children participate in conceptualizing, implementing, monitoring, and evaluating disaster risk reduction activities.
6. Community participation is very important in managing disasters. Disaster management is everybody's responsibility. Stress is given on building capacity at the national, local, and community levels for an integrated and responsive disaster risk reduction and management system.
7. The assistance covers material, social, and motivational aspects to reduce vulnerability.
8. Attention is spread among individual, family, and community preparedness. Disaster management is linked to community development.
9. The community participates in decision-making to prioritize needs and risk-reduction solutions or measures.
10. Disaster management aims to reduce people's vulnerabilities and increase capacities to better prepare and cope with disasters.

Basically, the goal is to build a safe, disaster-resilient, and developed community and society (CDP, 1984).

Essential Requisites of CBDRRM

The CBDRRM-based experiences of various NGOs and POs in CBDRRM point to the following essential requisites:

1. Capability Building in Disaster Management—sustained education and training activities; sustained public awareness using local language and culture.
2. Community Disaster Response Organization—disaster management teams, disaster response committee, disaster management committee, disaster management network, etc.
3. Counter Disaster Plan—emergency/contingency plan; counter-disaster plan; preparedness and mitigation plan; community development plan.
4. Disasters Risk Reduction—Development Continuum—linking vulnerability reduction and capacity building to achieving sustainable people-centered development.
5. Partnerships in Disaster Risk Reduction—partnerships Of the vulnerable sectors with less vulnerable groups in CBDM; partnerships of the community with the local government, NGOs, and other communities.

Reference:

Lanada, M.I.B., Melegrito, M.L.F., & Mendoza, D.J. (2016). *Building resilient communities: Disaster readiness and risk reduction.* Phoenix Publishing House